November 2007. That day it sent emails to media outlets immediately prior to executing a series of bomb blasts in three cities in the North Indian state of Uttar Pradesh.[53] Additional emails and attacks followed: nine bomb blasts in busy markets in the city of Jaipur on 13 May 2008; eight low-intensity blasts in India's IT capital of Bangalore on 25 July 2008; sixteen synchronized explosions in Ahmedabad in the state of Gujarat the following day; and five bomb blasts in the capital, New Delhi, on 13 September 2008.[54] The Indian Mujahideen released a 14-page manifesto prior to the Ahmedabad bombings, which stated these attacks were in retaliation for the injustices meted out against Indian Muslims and made specific mention of the 2002 Gujarat riots.[55]

For many years, Lashkar's aim had been to recruit indigenous actors capable of launching terrorist attacks against India, while sending Pakistani foot soldiers to fight in Indian-administered Kashmir. As is evident, from 2005–2008 it was having more success with the former than the latter. By mid-2008 the Indian security services were getting to grips with the threat from homegrown jihadis, breaking up cells and capturing or killing operatives. Despite successful counter-terrorism measures, only one of the Indian Mujahideen founders, Mohammad Sadiq Israr Sheikh who was introduced in the previous chapter, was in custody at the time of writing. Most of the key commanders were fugitives and Indian officials alleged they were hiding in Pakistan and Bangladesh. Several captured operatives reportedly confirmed the presence of Indian commanders in Karachi, where they were believed to play a role in coordinating with Lashkar, South Asian criminal syndicates (some of whose members also remain based in Karachi) and operatives in India.[56] Meanwhile, the number of Pakistani militants the group was successfully sending across the LoC had dwindled, and many of those in Indian-administered Kashmir were laying low. The group was born in 1986 during the anti-Soviet jihad in Afghanistan. Twenty years later, more of its members were returning there to wage war against America and its allies.

Separateness and Togetherness

Musharraf's decision to side with the US in the wake of the 9/11 attacks necessitated forsaking the Taliban in Afghanistan. However, this did not